FROM THE

EDITOR-IN-CHIEF

Politics never pauses for breath in India. Four months after the Lok Sabha election, Haryana voted in early October, along with Jammu and Kashmir. Though relatively minor assembly polls, they changed the state of play much beyond their local turfs. Haryana, especially, stopped in its tracks a creeping sense that the BJP was beginning to ebb. Having clearly worked on its game, Team Modi proved more than combat-fit and capable of springing a surprise even on a battlefield heavily loaded against it. It secured a resounding mandate; the extra momentum came for free. With that wind in the sail, it goes for the next match in the national round-robin league against the Opposition INDIA bloc. At stake this time is a much bigger prize: Maharashtra. As a companion match, there's also Jharkhand, voting in two phases: on November 13 and then with all of Maharashtra on November 20. Three days later, we will get another set of results that will hold much significance.

With a 288-seat assembly, Maharashtra is a vast electoral arena ruled for the past 30 years only by coalitions. Its polity is so fragmented that not one of the major parties in the fray, including the BJP, can win it on its own. At the macro level, it's a simple war for supremacy between the ruling Mahayuti alliance and the Opposition's Maha Vikas Aghadi (MVA). The Mahayuti has the BJP as its fulcrum, with two breakaway parties as its partners: Chief Minister Eknath Shinde's Shiv Sena and Deputy CM Ajit Pawar's Nationalist Congress Party (NCP). The MVA brings together the other factions of the two parties, Uddhav Thackeray's Shiv Sena(UBT) and Sharad Pawar's NCP(SP), with the Congress. Both are somewhat messy coalitions formed more out of expediency than ideology and hardly free from the usual internecine turf battles. But this is held in check by their deep and common antipathy towards the rival coalition. That hostility flows from all the ruptures seen since the 2019 assembly election: a tumultuous phase of regime change effected and then fortified by the cleaving apart of two regional parties with much salience in Maharashtra. Therefore, we have a war animated by several axes of intense personal rivalries.

Think of it as a multi-star cast canvas with a mosaic of individual battles. Uddhav is caught in a one-on-one struggle with Shinde for prestige and ownership of the Sena legacy. Sharad Pawar wants to eliminate the threat posed by his nephew Ajit for good and reclaim the patent for the NCP. Once seen as a minor league pawn parachuted to power, Shinde has shown himself to be a shrewd player. In the Lok Sabha election, he defied a consensus that Uddhav had the popular sympathy. His party won 7 of the 15 seats it contested against the Uddhav faction's 9 out of 21. Ajit Pawar suffered in that bout, winning only 1 seat out of 4; NCP(SP) won a conclusive 8 out of 10. But Sharad Pawar is not done. If he wins this contest too, the implications for his nephew are dire: Ajit stares at nothing short of political oblivion. Only party backing makes life easier for the other deputy CM, Devendra Fadnavis of the BJP. He is forced to play second fiddle to a CM, so his image has taken a hit. He, too, is in a struggle for political relevance.



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So, the election may decide the political fate of four major leaders and two regional parties. But for Team Modi and the Congress, all this is background noise to their competition to wrest the national narrative. They, too, have seen shifting fortunes. Congress had a surprise run in the Lok Sabha poll, winning 13 out of the 17 seats it contested. It was all set to take those bragging rights into seat-sharing talks, but Haryana delivered a reality check. The BJP won only 9 out of 28 contested battles but got a morale boost after the stunning Haryana win. The Lok Sabha election left the war unfinished and undecided for all sides. That's what is being resumed, with each assembly constituency across five regions magnified into a battlefield.

Senior Associate Editor Dhaval S. Kulkarni takes us to the beating heart of this war with a SWOT analysis of each player. A sense of Maharashtrian pride is at stake, both politically and in the context of the developmental journey of one of India's most industrialised states, home to its financial capital, Mumbai. Caste politics slices that up in unpredictable ways, with the Maratha agitation for OBC status setting off a counter-wave from those already on the list, alongside a parallel demand from the sizeable Dhangar community for tribal status. Hindutva is still very much in play, too. The RSS, reactivated in Haryana, will play a crucial role. The Mahayuti's Rs 46,000-crore Ladki Bahin scheme replays a stratagem employed in Madhya Pradesh to woo women voters. We have to see if its success will be replicated, too. Complicating things for both sides will be rebels and a third front of smaller parties. Senior Editor Amitabh Srivastava contributes a curtain-raiser on Jharkhand, where the recent incarceration of CM Hemant Soren, presently on bail, sets up an emotive battle. The results of these assembly polls will naturally have repercussions on the national stage.

(Aroon Purie)